DRAFT

Evacuating Children and Animals

Assign a person, safe way to travel, and confirmed destination for every child and animal before an evacuation.

EVS-006

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Life safety comes first. Animal loading can take significant time. Begin early when officials advise preparation, especially for livestock—but never delay escape from immediate danger to find, catch, or load an animal.

CHILDREN

- ☐ **Assign caregivers:** name a primary adult and a backup for each child. Make sure each person accepts the role and has needed car seats, medicines, access items, and contact information.
- ☐ **Follow reunification rules:** learn each school or childcare site's emergency notification, relocation, identification, and authorized-pickup process. Go to the location officials announce; do not rush to a school or care site unless directed.
- ☐ **Carry identification:** give the child age-appropriate household and emergency-contact information. Keep a current photo and key medical, allergy, communication, and custody or pickup information with the caregiver.
- ☐ **Pack familiar essentials:** include required medicines and support items, plus a comfort item, quiet activity, hearing protection, and a communication card or device when useful.
- ☐ **Practice without frightening:** explain likely sounds and steps in simple, age-appropriate language. Practice holding hands, going to the meeting place, using a car seat, stating a caregiver's name, and following a trusted adult.

Primary caregiver: _____ **Backup:** _____
School/care reunification instructions kept at: _____

PETS AND SERVICE ANIMALS

A service animal is not a pet. When confirming transportation and shelter, identify it as a service animal and ask officials about current access and shelter procedures for the animal and handler. Pet admission or co-sheltering rules may differ. Do not assume that any destination accepts pets.

- ☐ Keep identification and contact details on each animal when appropriate. Carry a current photo of the animal with its handler or owner, microchip information, and recovery contacts.
- ☐ Assign a primary and backup handler. Practice using the labeled carrier, crate, leash, harness, or other species-appropriate restraint that will travel with the animal.
- ☐ Pack medicines, dosing and care instructions, veterinary and vaccination records, food, water, bowls, and any gear needed for a service animal's work.
- ☐ Pack litter or bedding, waste bags, absorbent material, cleaning supplies, and other species-appropriate sanitation items.
- ☐ Confirm a primary and backup animal-accepting destination before an incident and again when leaving. Ask what species, records, equipment, and arrangements the site currently accepts.

Evacuating Children and Animals — continued

Animal / handler: _____ **Backup:** _____
Confirmed destination / phone: _____

LIVESTOCK AND LARGE ANIMALS

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Move early or move yourself: loading large animals requires time, suitable equipment, capable handlers, and usable routes. Start at the early trigger in your plan when officials advise preparation. If conditions become immediately dangerous, leave without delaying for an animal.

- ☐ **Set early decision triggers:** use official alerts and local direction, plus the time needed to gather handlers, reach the animals, load, and travel before routes or conditions become unsafe.
- ☐ **Know transport capacity:** inventory animals and confirm enough suitable tow vehicles, trailers, cages, fuel, loading space, and trips. Stay within vehicle and trailer limits.
- ☐ **Assign trailers and handlers:** identify capable primary and backup drivers and handlers. Keep halters, leads, panels, loading aids, keys, and protective equipment ready.
- ☐ **Confirm destinations:** contact the receiving location and responsible local authority. Confirm route, opening, capacity, unloading, identification and health-record requirements, biosecurity, feed, water, shelter, and daily care.
- ☐ **Identify animals:** maintain an inventory, current photos, owner contact details, and permanent or temporary identification appropriate for the species.
- ☐ **Follow local direction:** local officials determine safe routes, activated facilities, movement restrictions, and incident-specific livestock instructions. Follow current livestock-evacuation direction from emergency management and the responsible animal or agricultural authorities.

Early trigger: _____
Trailer / driver / handlers: _____
Destination confirmed with / date: _____

IF THE HOUSEHOLD IS SEPARATED

1. **Follow instructions where you are.** A child stays with the responsible school, childcare site, or caregiver until released through that site's process.
2. **Use assigned retrievers.** Record who is authorized and equipped to retrieve each child, pet, service animal with its handler, or livestock group. Share any written authorization and access instructions in advance.
3. **Call the backup.** If the primary person cannot act, contact the named backup and the out-of-area household contact. Tell them what officials have directed and where the dependent or animal is believed to be.
4. **Do not go into danger.** Never enter an unsafe, evacuated, or closed area to retrieve a child, dependent, or animal. Tell emergency officials what help is needed and follow their direction.

Evacuating Children and Animals — continued

Child, dependent, or animal	Authorized retriever / handler	Backup and phone
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

PRACTICE AND MAINTENANCE

- ☐ Practice calm carrier, vehicle, and trailer loading. Include the actual handlers and equipment, but stop if a drill would endanger a person or animal.
- ☐ Time the loading drill and use the result to move the early-action trigger sooner if needed.
- ☐ Reconfirm school and childcare release procedures and every human- and animal-accepting destination. Check alternatives, routes, hours, capacity, and contact details.
- ☐ Update child and animal photos, identification, medicine lists, veterinary and vaccination records, care instructions, pickup authorizations, and emergency contacts.
- ☐ Inspect carriers, restraints, car seats, trailers, tires, lights, hitches, brakes, gates, ramps, loading aids, sanitation supplies, batteries, and communication devices.

Check	Last completed	Next review / action
Child plan and reunification rules	_____	_____
Pet / service-animal loading and destination	_____	_____
Livestock loading, transport, and destination	_____	_____
Photos, identification, medicines, and records	_____	_____
Carriers, restraints, vehicles, and trailers	_____	_____

Evacuating Children and Animals — continued

USE WITH THE REST OF THE PLAN

- Use **STH-005 — Child & Caregiver Planning** for medicines, equipment, communication, transportation, and caregiver support.
- Use **STH-006 — Animal Planning** for the detailed animal inventory, supplies, handling notes, and backup transport plan.
- Use **EVS-003** for leave-early decision points, **EVS-004** for routes and destinations, **EVS-005** for transportation, **EVS-007** for shelter-in-place planning, and **EVS-009** for return. Follow current official instructions if a worksheet conflicts with incident direction.

SOURCES

Sources: Ready Kids, “Make a Plan”; Ready.gov, “Pets and Animals”; U.S. Department of Justice Civil Rights Division, “Frequently Asked Questions about Service Animals and the ADA”; and USDA APHIS, “Animal Health Emergency Management.” Accessed 2026-09-25. Confirm school, childcare, shelter, transport, livestock, and evacuation procedures with the responsible local organizations.